

Psychological First Aid for Young Peers

A HANDBOOK

Belize City Lions Club
MENTAL HEALTH COMMITTEE



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Introduction

Life as a young person in Belize comes with its own set of challenges, from intense academic pressure to navigating social trauma. Psychological First Aid (PFA) equips you with practical skills that makes a real difference:

- **Be a better friend:** learn how to engage in active listening and offer effective, empowering support to peers in distress without making them feel dependent.
- **Prioritise your own well-being:** Gain essential self-care tools so you don't burn out.
- **Never walk alone:** Connect with a network of peer supporters so you aren't carrying someone else's stress by yourself.

This handbook and accompanying training on PFA will build your skills and knowledge to help others who may be in distress or experiencing difficulties. It will build your confidence to offer personal support to your friends or more formally as a volunteer in response to incidents such as natural disasters where help by a National Society or other community group is offered.

Why is Psychological First Aid (PFA) helpful?

PFA is a step-by-step way to show up for someone going through a tough time. It's all about showing genuine care, paying attention to how a person is feeling, listening without judgement, and stepping in with practical support when needed. Simply put, PFA lets a young person know that they aren't alone when they need support most.

PFA skills include knowing:

- how to approach someone who may need help
- how people can feel in difficult situations
- how to calm someone who is distressed
- how to help someone find the practical help they may need
- how to recognise severe signs of distress and to make referrals to the appropriate services.

PFA can be applied to many different situations and challenges. It is often used during large-scale emergencies that affect whole communities, like mass casualty road accidents, extreme weather events like hurricanes or flooding that damage schools, or humanitarian crises where families are forced to leave their homes. In these major situations, official organisations like Belize City Lions Club (or other national societies) lead the response, and trained PFA volunteers step in under their guidance to offer organised, safe support.

PFA is...

- Helping someone feel safe and calm
- Finding out what they need and are worried about
- Protecting them from further harm or danger
- Providing emotional support
- Helping with immediate problems
- Connecting them with people they know
- Connecting them with community services and other help

PFA is not...

- Only for professionals or experts
- Psychological therapy or counselling
- Exploring why something happened
- Exploring the deeper meaning of what happened
- Asking someone to share every detail
- Pressuring someone to talk about their feelings

Beyond large emergencies, PFA helps young people navigate everyday personal challenges, including academic stress, family conflict, bullying, identity exploration, online violence, or substance misuse. Whether serving as a community volunteer or simply being a supportive friend, young peers can use PFA to offer crucial early support. While feeling anxious or overwhelmed by these stressors is completely normal, PFA also helps to recognise when a situation requires long-term, specialised professional care.

PFA for young peers

This package is designed for youths between ages 12 to 23 years. ‘Peers’ are people who are around the same age and stage in life, sharing the same or similar experiences, who can relate to one another. The definition used in this training is, “**A peer is someone your age and equal to you who shares similar experiences.**”

Peer relationships are very important during adolescence and young adult years. Young people of the same age may find it easier to share their problems with their peers and friends instead of with adults in their life.

We believe that this package will ensure that young peers have the skills and knowledge to help and support each other by using PFA. After completing the PFA training you can use the knowledge and skills learned to offer peer support in person, over the phone, or remotely, depending on what the situation calls for.

PFA gives you a simple, flexible framework to help someone in distress: **LOOK**, **LISTEN**, and **LINK**. Just remember, in the real world, helping someone isn’t a straight line, you’ll naturally weave back and forth between looking, listening, and linking as you support a peer.



LOOK	LISTEN	LINK
• What happened? • What is happening? • Who needs help? • Safety risks • Signs of distress or injury • Emotional reactions • Immediate basic & practice needs	• Approach the person • Introduce yourself • Pay attention & listen actively • Accept their feelings • Help them feel calm • Ask about needs & concerns • Help find solutions to immediate needs & problems	• Make relevant information, services, and other sources of assistance available • Help them connect or reunite with trusted persons • Provide social support • Actively try to help solve the issue(s).

Turn to the next page for a case study that illustrates LOOK, LISTEN, and LINK.

A road accident

It is a busy morning in Belize City. Kelly is walking to school along Central American Boulevard. Suddenly, she sees her classmate Kevin riding his bicycle when a car hits him.

The driver does not stop and speeds away.

Kevin falls hard onto the road and screams in pain. His bicycle is badly damaged, and his backpack has ripped opened. His books are scattered across the street.

Kelly carefully runs to Kevin and waves at the approaching cars to slow down and stop. She checks to see if Kevin is hurt. His arm looks broken, but she is not sure.

Kelly quickly moves the bicycle out of the way of the road and helps Kevin to the sidewalk. She asks someone walking past to call an ambulance. She also tells Kevin that she will call his brother.

Kelly tells Kevin that help is on the way. She asks how he is feeling and if he needs anything. Kevin feels scared and in a lot of pain, especially in his arm. She comforts him and tells him she will stay with him until the ambulance arrives.

While they wait, Kelly picks up Kevin's books from the street and puts them back in his bag. She checks on Kevin again and asks if his pain is getting worse.

The police and ambulance arrive. Kelly explains to the police what she saw. The ambulance takes Kevin to the hospital.

Kelly stays with Kevin's bicycle and waits for his brother to arrive. When he arrives, she explains what happened and tells him that Kevin was taken to KHMHA.



A. LOOK

In PFA, LOOK refers to how you look at a situation to see if it is safe to offer help. You have to assess what kind of help is needed and whether or not you can provide help. LOOK also means noticing how the person in distress is reacting. What is the best type of safe and effective support they need?

Discussion Questions for Case Study 1:

1. What signs showed Kelly that Kevin needed help?
2. What safety risks and dangers did Kelly need to look out for?
3. What did Kelly notice about Kevin's physical condition?
4. What did Kelly notice about how Kevin was feeling?
5. What kind of help did Kevin need right away?
6. What could Kelly do herself, and when did she need help from others?
7. What could have gone wrong if Kelly had rushed in without checking the situation first?
8. If you were Kelly, what would you LOOK for before helping someone in a similar situation?

In the case study, Kevin needed immediate help from doctors because of his physical injuries. However, after a stressful or frightening event, some people may experience psychological distress even if they are not physically injured. LOOK also means noticing signs that someone may be experiencing psychological distress and may need additional support.

Signs of psychological distress

Many people will have strong reactions during and/or after a difficult or stressful event. Some people may need professional support. Look out for signs such as:

- Depressed mood, fatigue
- Becoming easily frustrated or irritated
- Changes in sleeping and eating patterns
- Trouble concentrating
- Risky or impulsive behaviours, e.g., excessive drug/alcohol use, aggression
- Withdrawal from friends, family, and activities that used to be enjoyable
- Neglect of personal care, such as not eating or maintaining personal hygiene, even when food and washing facilities are available
- Threatening to hurt themselves or someone else

If you notice these signs, LINK the person to appropriate professional support.

B. LISTEN

In PFA, LISTEN means how you communicate with someone who is upset or in distress.

Listening is more than just hearing someone's words. It means:

- Being present and paying attention
- Giving the person time to speak
- Trying to understand what they are saying
- Paying attention to how they are feeling
- Finding out what they need
- Being open, patient, and respectful

For example, you can repeat back what someone has said in your own words and ask, **“Is that what you mean?”** This shows that you are listening and gives them a chance to correct or explain anything.

Turn to the next page for a case study that illustrates LISTEN.

Listening to a friend

David and John are good friends since primary school. They often ride their bicycles around the neighbourhood in the evenings to hangout and train for races.

One day, after a ride, John tells David that he has been dealing with a lot lately. John says he has been avoiding people. More and more, he does not feel like hanging out with friends because it is too much on top of everything.

David is worried, so he listens as John talks about what is stressing him out. He gives John his full attention, nods to show he is listening, and lets him finish without interrupting.

After John finishes talking, David nods and says, “That sound real stressful, I hear you. You got plenty pon your plate. I deh yah if you want talk more.”

They cycle back home. Before they part, they agree to meet again soon. The next day, David sends John a text: “Afternoon, breda. Just checking fi see how you deh. You wah go ride again this evening?”

That evening, after their usual ride, John tells David that he is thinking about going to counselling at the Hub at the Community Centre.

David asks, “You want me fi go with you? I know where the Hub deh. I went there for an event before.”

John says no, but asks if they can meet up to ride afterwards. David agrees.

“Alright, breda. Text me when you done. I wah see if I can beat you this time when we ride.”



Discussion Questions for Case Study 2:

1. What did David do that showed John he was listening?
2. How did David give John space to talk about what was troubling him?
3. What did David do after their conversation to continue supporting John?
4. Why was it important that David asked John if he wanted him to go to the Hub with him?
5. What could David have done differently that might have made John feel uncomfortable or pressured?
6. What is one thing you could do if a friend told you they were going through something similar?

C. LINK

In PFA, LINK is about helping someone get the support and resources they need.

This can include:

- Helping someone find useful information
- Connecting them with family, friends, or other people they trust
- Connecting them with services that can help
- Helping them solve practical problems
- Using your own strengths, such as staying calm and focused, to support the person

It is important to know what services are available in your community. You can find information about local services at the end of this booklet.

Turn to the next page for a case study that illustrates LINK.

Shocking news

Sol was volunteering at a summer camp when she checked her social media. She saw a post saying that her uncle had been involved in a serious accident at the factory where he worked. He had passed away while being taken to the hospital.

Sol broke down crying. Her friend Jessica noticed and quickly went over to her and offered to help. She moved Sol to a quiet area away from the other campers and activities, then informed one of the camp coordinators about what had happened.

Jessica returned to Sol with a glass of water and a tissue. She asked Sol if she wanted to call her mom to come pick her up from the camp. While they waited, Jessica stayed with Sol and asked how she was feeling.

Sol said she was worried about how her cousins and younger brother would take the news. Jessica reminded Sol that it was important to take care of herself first, rather than worrying about everyone else right away.

After a while, Jessica went to check whether anyone had arrived to pick Sol up. She saw Sol's mother turning into the parking lot and went back to let Sol know.

Jessica walked with Sol to the car and helped her gather her belongings. She made sure Sol had her bag and water bottle before leaving with her mother.



Discussion Questions for Case Study 3:

1. What did Jessica notice about Sol that showed she needed support?
2. How did Jessica make the situation safer and more comfortable for Sol?
3. What did Jessica do to show that she was there for Sol?
4. How did Jessica help Sol get the support she needed?
5. Why do you think Jessica stayed with Sol while she waited for her mom?
6. Was Jessica right to remind Sol to focus on herself first? Why or why not?
7. What practical things did Jessica do to help Sol?
8. What other support might Sol need after leaving the camp?
9. If you were Jessica, is there anything else you would do? Why?

Do No Harm

Even when we have good intentions, we can accidentally make things harder for someone when we try to help. To provide PFA safely and respectfully, keep these guidelines in mind:

Protect Privacy and Trust

Keep what someone shares private. The exception is when they may hurt themselves or someone else, or are in immediate danger. In these situations, connect them to appropriate professional help right away. This includes emergency care, counselling services, or youth protection services.

Give Emotional and Practical Support

Offer comfort and practical help when you can. Do not press for details or ask intrusive questions, as this can increase their stress.

Listen Actively

Put away your phone and minimise distractions. Active listening shows the person that they truly matter and are being heard.

Stay Open and Non-Judgemental

Do not judge, blame, criticise, or lecture. Make it safe for the person to talk and ask for help. Criticism and judgement create shame and prevents people from seeking the help they really need.

Let the Person Make Their Own Decisions

Do not tell someone what they *should* do. Help by exploring their options with them and letting them decide what feels right and works best.

Be Honest and Trustworthy

Never make promises you can't keep or offer false hope just to make the person feel better. If you do not know something, it is okay to say, "I don't know, but we can find out."

Know Your Limits

You do not have to solve every problem yourself. Know what you can and cannot handle.

If someone needs more help than you can provide, LINK them to appropriate services.

Don't Force Help

Sometimes people are not ready to accept help. Do not pressure or force them. Let them know that support is available when they are ready.

End Your Support Respectfully

Do not suddenly leave someone who is still in distress. Before you leave, explain what support or services are available. Make sure they know how to access further help if they need it.

Self-care and Support

Helping others can sometimes be stressful or tiring. That is why it is important to take care of yourself too.

You may have heard the saying, “**You cannot pour from an empty cup.**” It means that you cannot support others well if you are exhausted, overwhelmed, or burnt out.

Feeling tired or stressed does not mean you are weak. It is a normal and healthy part of being human. Taking care of yourself helps you stay healthy and continue supporting others.

You can use LOOK, LISTEN, and LINK to take care of yourself too.

LOOK

Pay attention to how you are feeling and how your body is reacting.

You can refer back to the **Signs of Psychological Distress** section earlier in this booklet to recognise signs of psychological distress.

You may also notice physical signs of distress in yourself, such as:

- Constant tiredness or low energy
- Unexplained aches, headaches, or stomach-aches
- Digestive problems, e.g., nausea, diarrhea
- Chest pain or feeling like your heart is racing

These signs can be your body's way of telling you that you may need to slow down, rest, or ask for support.

LISTEN

Once you've noticed signs of distress, pause and ask what's behind them. Tune in to your internal reactions and listen to the thoughts and emotions underneath the physical signs you have noticed.

You might recognize negative thought patterns, which can increase anxiety or stress, such as:

- All-or-Nothing Thinking: “If this is hard, then I must not be good at it.”
- Overgeneralization: “That interaction went badly. I always mess things up.”
- Discounting the Positive: “I did well, but it was probably just luck.”
- Jumping to Conclusions: “They seem quiet. They must be upset with me.”
- Catastrophizing: “If I cannot handle this well, it is going to become a disaster.”
- Should Statements: “I should be handling this better.” Or “I should not feel this way.”
- Rumination: repeatedly going over the same thoughts or problems, looping “what if” or “why did this happen” scenarios

These thought patterns are associated with self-criticism, overthinking, and worst-case-scenario thinking.

Just as you would acknowledge someone else's feelings without judgement when providing PFA, offer yourself the same compassion. Recognize that these are unhelpful thinking patterns – not facts – that can make situations feel more negative, extreme, or hopeless than they really are.

If you recognize one of these patterns in your thinking, you can gently question it: “What would I say to a friend who had this thought?”

This is a powerful first step. It also helps to act, not just reflect. Research in mental health shows that doing meaningful or enjoyable activities – even briefly, even when you don’t feel like it – can improve mood and break cycles of stress more effectively than waiting to “feel ready” first. Notice what's been pulling you away from rest or the things you usually enjoy, and treat re-engaging with them as part of your recovery, not a reward for feeling better first.

LINK

Connect with your support network. Talk to friends or peers about what you’re experiencing, or simply spend time together going for a walk, hanging out, or playing sports.

If you realise you need specialised or focused support, reach out for it and consider asking a trusted friend to help you make that connection if you don’t feel you can do it on your own.

As a young peer providing PFA, having a supervisor or mentor is a crucial safeguard. This could be a teacher trained in PFA, guidance counsellor, or community volunteer coordinator such as LEO’s advisor, who is available to provide support after responding to an incident. Always make sure you understand what support is available to you and how to access it whenever you need it.

Making referrals¹

Referral services	Contact details
Emergency services	
Police	
Fire	
Ambulance	
Child protection services	
Health services	
Counselling services for young people	
GBV help and support	
LGBTQIA+ counselling services	

¹ Information on local services should be provided by the facilitators of the PFA training which accompanies this handbook

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